



When Mice Were Wooden

It's clichéd to say we live in a technologically advanced world, but just five decades ago, a mouse was only something a cat chased. It's all zoomed by us—almost too fast

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“History is bunk,” flatly and famously stated Henry Ford in 1916. We don't quite agree. Sure, we can let bygones be bygones, but if what was done a fifty or a hundred years ago endures, if it has changed the way we live, if it has enriched our lives—we're interested. What was computing like when there were no mice and—the horror of it!—no colour displays? A passion for technology is not limited to checking out the latest graphics cards. We want to know how it all happened: how we got married to the phenomenon called technology.

This is not a history lesson. It's a celebration of five decades of tech, and not to forget, a tribute to the men who made it all happen.

So, while the hippies were lying on the grass and getting stoned, not everyone was convinced that that was where the good life was. Researchers in corporate and university labs were, for the ultimate good of mankind, engaged in serious work (yes, there was a lot of that in the '60s, too). And they weren't working on their laptops from the comfort of their homes: they got down to the dirty, as in actual hands-on work with primitive components. A few dreamers here and there wrote seminal papers. And companies—some small, some large—intro-

duced devices, some that fizzled out, some that endured.

The audio cassette, invented in this decade, endured. It started off the whole portable music thing. Of course, it was the Walkman, brought out much later, that actually put cassettes to good use.

Laser mice and multi-button mice are all fine, but how about a word of thanks to Doug Engelbart, who invented the device in the '60s? It was a “primitive” device—carved from (ugh) wood—but it did the job. (Actually, wooden mice seem to us a cool retro idea—we found a couple on eBay!) While on the subject of inventions, Xerox came out with the Telecopier—the first successful fax machine. And if you can think of a programming language as an invention, BASIC—as in VB, only a lot less capable—was invented this decade. Ah, the simple joys of life! LET $x=10$; LET $y=20$; LET $a = x + y$; PRINT a ! That was probably the first program many of us at *Digit* ever wrote...

...because BASIC really was pretty basic, and became popular with folks learning to program. We were surprised when our in-house programmer told us it's been around since the '60s!

If you can imagine a world with no computer games, you don't need to think beyond the '60s—that was when the first video game came out: Spacewar!. It generated no little excitement—people liked the idea of actually

being able to use their computers for business as well as pleasure, and wherever there were computers—mostly labs—Spacewar! was being played.

You might or might not believe how simple Spacewar! was. It was a two-player game, and each player controlled a spaceship, meaning a little white blotch on the screen. There was a star that pulled you towards it—and you had to avoid the star. The players shot at each other: the bullets were little dots. Take a look for yourself—you can play a Java version of the original game at <http://lcs.www.media.mit.edu/groups/el/projects/spacewar/>.

Actually, the first video game wasn't Spacewar! either. Spacewar! was the first game “intended for computer use,” according to some sources. The first “graphical computer game” is “widely believed” to have been Tic-Tac-Toe (or “Noughts and Crosses,” depending on your source) by A.S. Douglas in 1952. According to pong-story.com, “the game was played against the machine. Once the game started, the player specified where he wanted to place his nought or cross using a *mechanical telephone dialler*.” (!) Not much of a game—and we think we can safely say Spacewar! was “the first computer game.”

It might come as a surprise that robotics predates computers (the way we think of them, at least). In 1961 was marketed the

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